

## Chapter 27-3

Upon hearing this, the editor-in-chief immediately widened her eyes, "I'm short-sighted? I've been in the magazine industry for so many years, my eye for people has always been accurate. Do I need a newcomer like you to teach me how to do my job?"

"Then why haven't you been able to finalize a topic selection?" Liang Shi deftly countered.

Her expression remained very calm throughout, her gaze toward the editor-in-chief carrying a hint of coldness, yet without strong aggression. Even so, it was enough to make people feel her presence, "As an editor-in-chief, shouldn't your responsibility be coordination? As far as I know, the planning department provided you with five topic proposals, each one rejected by you, but the reasons you gave were all 'no novelty,' 'been done before,' 'not good,' but where exactly they're not good, you never say. You just demand everyone keep revising, keep changing, you can't even provide a direction for adjustment. Are you sure you've seriously considered this? Have you respected the creativity of your planning department colleagues? With your demands, even if the magazine needs to go to press, you still won't be able to finalize topics. The magazine will definitely have blank pages<sup>1</sup>."

Everyone present gasped.

They all looked at Liang Shi with admiring eyes, seeing only two words in their expressions—warrior.

Finally someone had said what they hadn't dared to say these past few days!

"What bullshit are you talking!" The editor-in-chief became emotional, "If you're so capable, you come up with the topic selection! The topics they came up with were garbage to begin with, showing no professionalism at all. At this rate, having blank pages is inevitable, but what does that have to do with me? You bunch of incapable people—the planning department can't come up with topics, the editorial department's articles are a mess, the advertising department can't attract ads that align with our magazine's concept despite backing from Dongheng. Such a magazine is bound to have problems because the staff is incompetent!"

Everyone's faces changed.

This was practically pointing at everyone's noses and cursing!

But precisely because of Dongheng's prestigious reputation and the high salaries here, no one dared to speak up.

Anyone who spoke up now would truly be the nail that sticks out and gets hammered down<sup>2</sup>—they'd definitely be fired.

So everyone could only turn their gaze to Liang Shi, watching to see if this newcomer dared to continue the confrontation.

And Liang Shi laughed upon hearing her words.

The editor-in-chief scolded, "What the hell are you laughing at?"

Liang Shi replied calmly, "I'm laughing at you."

Editor-in-chief: "..."

In such a tense atmosphere, someone accidentally laughed.

Then several more people got Liang Shi's cold joke<sup>3</sup> and covered their mouths, laughing softly.

The editor-in-chief's sharp gaze swept over them, and they all fell silent again.

Liang Shi said, "Do you know what your current behavior looks like?"

She spoke word by word: "Incompetent rage."

"You've pushed all the responsibility onto your subordinates, thinking you're the most innocent one. But you're the one who rejected all the proposals, and you're not even part of this magazine's target demographic, yet you're arbitrarily judging everything based on your own perspective. How could you possibly select suitable topics this way? In fact, you fundamentally cannot do this magazine well. I think the person who should leave the magazine department most is you." Liang Shi smiled with a hint of charm.

"You!" The editor-in-chief was furious, "You're just a newcomer..."

Before she could finish, Liang Shi interrupted, "Yes, I'm a newcomer, but I know that those in authority should listen widely, should observe and listen more, should respect others' work results. If you were truly a capable leader, even if your subordinates submitted a pile of garbage, you should be able to make that garbage shine again, instead of suppressing your subordinates here, elevating yourself by attacking others. Are you qualified to be a leader? What are your abilities? Cursing people? Or venting your anger on newcomers?"

She asked these questions calmly, but the editor-in-chief's face changed because of these words, looking at her with gritted teeth.

"I've worked in this industry for nearly twenty years. Do I need an inexperienced outsider like you to point fingers at me? Do you understand magazines? Do you know how to make magazines?"

"In 1867, America compiled the first fashion magazine 'HARPER'S BAZAAR,' the world's earliest women's fashion magazine. Initially focused only on clothing, it gradually encompassed beauty, leisure, jewelry and other fields. Mainland China published and distributed its first fashion magazine 'Fashion' in 1980. By the 21st century, print media welcomed its golden age, but with technological advancement, print media went from rise to decline in less than thirty years. Now many print media have shut down, entering the new media era. Electronic publications have much higher circulation than print media, so what are you still being stubborn about? Do you think making magazines just requires ideals?" Liang Shi finished speaking without any emotion, while posing questions to her.

She didn't know much about magazines before, only because she was in that circle, so she was involved in some aspects.

Before coming to work at Dongheng, she deliberately researched materials, looking into magazines' origins and current predicaments, and had some thoughts of her own.

Now she was taking the opportunity to express her thoughts.

"Haiwei Jewelry could launch their own publication in a short time and become a first-class magazine in the industry. Do you think their editor-in-chief achieved industry peak by constantly suppressing subordinates like you, making subordinates work overtime every day revising topic selections?" Liang Shi continued questioning.

"Yes, perhaps you were once an excellent magazine person, but times are changing now. You need traffic, readership, sales figures, and also magazine people's ideals. Shouldn't you be the one to balance these things? If you can't balance them well and need all your subordinates to do everything, then what's the point of having you as editor-in-chief? Is it to pay you money to curse people? Is this Dongheng's work environment?"

Her series of rhetorical questions left the editor-in-chief completely bewildered.

This floor was so quiet you could hear a pin drop.

The editor-in-chief, in her fury, threw a stack of A4 papers directly at her. Liang Shi calmly dodged.

The A4 papers fluttered down like falling snowflakes, scattered all over the floor.

Liang Shi looked at her and continued explaining: "Also, if I had magazine work experience, then I would directly replace your position. I would be airborne as magazine department head, not choose to come here as a small employee."

"Ha." The editor-in-chief angrily cursed, "So you're fucking a connections hire, what's there to be proud of? If you have the ability, fucking push me out directly! What bullshit are you spouting here? If you don't have the ability, go back to work. Coming here to show off to me, right? Showing how impressive you are? If you're the CEO's daughter, why didn't you get airborne directly to the president's office!"

"I came to the magazine department voluntarily," Liang Shi said. "But I came here to work, not to accept personal attacks. I believe all colleagues present feel the same. Everyone has self-respect and can accept being criticized. But I hope you understand that criticism and abuse are not the same word. As a leader, you don't have the right to attack your subordinates. You are depriving everyone present of their personal dignity."

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## Footnotes:

1. **開天窗 (kāi tiān chuāng)** - Literally "opening skylights," this is a publishing term meaning to have blank spaces or missing content in a publication due to lack of material or content being pulled at the last minute.
2. **槍打出頭鳥 (qiāng dǎ chū tóu niǎo)** - "The gun shoots the bird that sticks its head out" - a Chinese saying meaning that those who stand out or speak up first often become targets and face punishment.
3. **冷笑話 (lěng xiào huà)** - "Cold joke" - refers to a pun, wordplay, or joke that's so bad it's funny, often causing people to groan or laugh despite themselves. In this context, Liang Shi's matter-of-fact "I'm laughing at you" response to "What are you laughing at?" is unexpectedly direct and humorous.